

principles. Remember that obedience to God is an indicator, not an absolute. Our relationship with God fluctuates sometimes and so will that of our children. It's the life patterns that provide the indicators. Also let me assure you that a slothful, indulgent child will almost always develop into a slothful, indulgent adult. The sooner you spot the faults, the sooner you can help to correct them.

Children coming out of Christian families quite often see one thing and hear another. Parents are the best (or worst) models of Christianity their children will see. Remember what James said? "Prove yourselves doers of the Word, and not merely hearers who delude themselves" (James 1:22).

Al and Carol became Christians about 10 years into their marriage, though from different sides of the fence. Carol was of the charismatic persuasion and Al was a fundamentalist. He thought she was nuts and she thought he was unsaved. But the real losers in their frequent yelling matches were their children.

Carol came from a wealthy background where money was the equivalent of a person's value. Her father was the chairman of every board or committee in the church, and her mother ruled her father.

Al's parents were divorced while he was still in high school and he grew up to be a "self-made" man who resisted any woman's hint at authority. Theirs was a situation ripe for Satan to exploit.

Their children were *sent* to church and Sunday School because Al wouldn't attend Carol's church and wouldn't allow their children to attend either. Often he wouldn't go to church because of a heated argument on Sunday morning. So he would drop off the kids and just drive around.

The impact that church made on their children was basically zero. They heard about love and understanding at Sunday School but witnessed warfare at home, much of it motivated by spiritual differences.

Carol began making a habit of running home every time she and Al would have a fight. The kids were usually caught in the